

Steven Johnston

TECHNICAL LEAD & SOLUTIONS ARCHITECT

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SC CLEARED

CCNP ENTERPRISE

CCNP COLLABORATION

PROFILE

Technical leader designing and delivering secure, enterprise-scale infrastructure across critical national infrastructure, energy, public sector and education. I operate at lead architect level: owning end-to-end architecture, setting standards across concurrent programmes, and seeing complex multi-vendor deployments through to production. Live estates migrate the same way every time: the new platform is built and proven alongside the old, the cutover is reduced to the smallest possible change, and every step carries a documented rollback.

My expertise spans networking, security, identity, cloud and AI-driven automation. I have led zero trust implementations for critical national infrastructure, separated operational technology from corporate IT for industrial estates, and architected cloud platforms bringing agentic AI into infrastructure operations. I manage and mentor a team of seven consultants, leading through shared knowledge bases and tooling so capability spreads across the team.

KEY SKILLS

Architecture & Strategy: Enterprise and solution architecture, technical strategy and roadmaps, design governance and assurance, high-level and low-level design, standards definition, design authority

Cloud & Hybrid: Public cloud networking and security (Azure), hybrid connectivity, transit hub architectures, multi-region resilient design

AI & Automation: Agentic AI for IT operations, large language model integration, Python, infrastructure as code

Leadership: Team leadership and mentoring, programme delivery, supplier and stakeholder management, executive communication

Security & Secure by Design: Zero trust architecture, secure access service edge (SASE), identity-based network access control, next-generation firewalls, secure remote access

Networking: Enterprise WAN and software-defined WAN, campus and datacentre networks, routing and traffic engineering

DevOps & Delivery: CI/CD pipelines, automated testing, agile delivery across concurrent programmes

Collaboration & Voice: Enterprise telephony and unified communications, cloud calling and Microsoft Teams voice, session border control, SIP integration and migration

EXPERIENCE

Technical Lead

2024 – Present

Sword Group (formerly Ping Network Solutions)

- Designed and delivered a resilient, multi-region zero trust network and security architecture in the public cloud for a **critical national infrastructure client**, spanning identity-based access control, next-generation firewalls and software-defined WAN
- Architected a secure cloud-based AI platform to automate network operations workflows, integrating large language model tooling with enterprise infrastructure to reduce manual effort and accelerate incident response
- Define solution architecture and set technical standards across concurrent projects, holding design authority through design reviews and architectural governance
- Manage and mentor a team of 7 consultants, owning resource planning, technical direction and professional development
- Lead architect on a greenfield dual-datacentre and WAN programme for an **M&A asset transition**: 25/100G fabric, petabyte-scale storage, a six-site SD-WAN replacing legacy MPLS, and a segregated **operational technology environment** isolated from corporate IT by zero trust segmentation
- Delivered campus-wide security and network refresh programmes across multiple Scottish public sector clients, including colleges, universities and government bodies, coordinating third-party suppliers throughout
- Designed a cloud-hosted identity platform giving centrally authenticated and audited administrative access to c.500 network devices for a **national gas network**

Consultant Engineer

2019 – 2024

Ping Network Solutions

- Delivered end-to-end solutions across networking, security, identity and collaboration, authoring the low-level design and migration runbook on each
- Led a multi-site migration from a legacy VPN estate to software-defined WAN, and architected resilient hybrid cloud connectivity around an active/active security transit hub
- Replaced end-of-life core, perimeter and identity platforms across two sites, retiring a legacy access control estate onto centralised device administration with multi-factor authentication
- Migrated a two-campus college between firewall vendors, running both live in parallel and **tightening an inherited any-to-any rule base** rather than copying it across
- Designed a secure multi-tenant monitoring and privileged access platform for a **critical national infrastructure operator**, with per-customer isolation and bastion access for third parties
- Migrated 2,000 users from on-premises telephony to cloud collaboration for a major Scottish university, and a transport operator off end-of-life TDM circuits to SIP

Principal Engineer

2015 – 2019

Virgin Media Business

- Provided technical leadership and consultation for large public sector accounts
- Delivered a comprehensive network and datacentre redesign for a national justice sector organisation
- Led a datacentre compute and infrastructure refresh for a secure public sector estate
- Designed and implemented a secure video conferencing system for a custodial environment, connecting inmates, solicitors, police and court personnel
- Delivered multiple large infrastructure projects including network refreshes, firewall migrations and voice integrations

Senior Network Engineer

2007 – 2015

Jabil

- Led a European-wide network and telephony refresh across 112 manufacturing sites
- Delivered two \$3M datacentre builds in London and Budapest
- Served as technical lead for the acquisition integration of a competitor facility in the Netherlands

Network Engineer

2003 – 2007

Jabil

- Managed converged data and voice network installations across the European region
- Designed routing and traffic engineering solutions for international networks
- Delivered VPN, telephony and wireless solutions across multiple European sites

CERTIFICATIONS & CLEARANCE

SC Cleared

UK Government Security Clearance (current)

CCNP Enterprise

Routing & Switching · valid through 2027

CCNP Collaboration

Unified Communications · valid through 2027

Cisco Specialist Certifications

Multiple · valid through 2027

PORTFOLIO

AI tools & agentic workflows: tools.clydeford.net, AI tools and agents built for the infrastructure problems I meet in delivery, including an autonomous device security auditor checking against NIST and CIS benchmarks, a network digital twin with human-approved remediation, and a telephony migration tool with dry-run validation